



tropical islands of the East Indies; while east to west it ranges through the desert countries of the Middle East—a distinct region bordering both Europe and Africa—across the majestic Himalayan mountain

range, and along to the volcanic islands of Japan and Philippines. The area south of the Himalayas is referred to as the Indian subcontinent because it is a distinct landmass jutting out of the body of the continent.

Asian statistics



LANGUAGES

Almost three times as many people use Mandarin Chinese as use English, the next most popular of the world's languages.

Mandarin Chinese	874 million
Bengali	189 million
Hindi	182 million
Russian	130 million



RELIGIONS

The majority of Asians do not subscribe to a major world faith, but to another religion which has a smaller and more local range.

Muslim	822 million
Hindu	815 million
Buddhist	338 million
Christian	315 million



URBAN POPULATION

Mumbai (formerly Bombay) has the largest urban population in Asia. The city struggles to provide facilities for so many people.

Mumbai	12.2 million
Karachi	11.2 million
Seoul	11.3 million
Manila	10.1 million



POPULATION BY COUNTRY

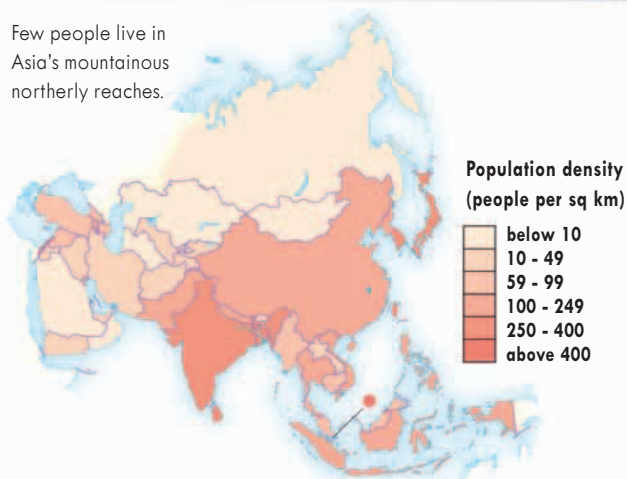
Around half of the world's 6.2 billion people live in Asia. China and India have the most people, not just in Asia, but in the world.

China	1,290 million
India	1,000 million
Indonesia	236 million
Russia	144 million

POPULATION

The Indian subcontinent and the many islands that make up Indonesia in the south of the continent are the most densely populated parts of Asia.

Few people live in Asia's mountainous northerly reaches.



ASIAN FACTS

PLACES

Number of countries	48
Highest point	Mount Everest, China-Nepal, 29,035 ft (8,850 m)
Lowest point	Dead Sea, Israel-Jordan, -1,293 ft (-394 m)
Longest river	Chang Jiang, (Yangtze), China 3,965 m (6,380 km)
Biggest island	Borneo
Biggest country	Russian Federation
Smallest country	Maldives

PEOPLE

Population of continent	3,674 million
Male life expectancy	65 years
Female life expectancy	68 years
Male literacy rate	82%
Female literacy rate	71%